The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

Donald Trump said **America** could end its war against **Iran** in two or three weeks, whether “we have a deal or not”. Marco Rubio, America’s secretary of state, suggested there is still “potential for a direct meeting” with Iran’s leaders. Earlier Masoud Pezeshkian, Iran’s president, said his country would consider ending the war if it receives “guarantees” against future attacks.

Asian and European **stocks** surged in response to the comments from America and Iran. South Korea’s KOSPI index jumped by more than 8%; Japan’s Topix by 4%; and Europe’s Stoxx 600 by more than 2%. The price of Brent crude, the global **oil** benchmark, fell to below $100, down from a high of $119 on Tuesday. America’s S&P 500 and NASDAQ indices also posted big gains on Tuesday.

Meanwhile, Iran’s **Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps**, a paramilitary force, warned it would start attacking facilities linked to American **tech companies** in the Middle East on Wednesday. Apple, Google, Microsoft, Nvidia and other tech firms would be considered “legitimate targets” in retaliation for American and Israeli strikes, the IRGC said. It also threatened non-tech firms such as JPMorgan Chase and Boeing.

Germany's most prominent economic institutes slashed their growth forecasts for 2026 because of the Iran war. The group of five research centres, which advises the government, now expects German GDP to grow by 0.6% in 2026 and 0.9% in 2027, compared with forecasts of 1.3% and 1.4% made in September. The institutes also expect inflation to be higher than previously forecast.

Meg O'Neill took the helm at BP, becoming Big Oil's first female chief executive. The American, who previously led Woodside Energy, an Australian company, told BP staff she wanted to provide "clear direction" following a turbulent period. Last year the British oil major reversed a pivot into clean energy after Elliott Management, an activist hedge fund, took a stake in the firm.

South Korean exports surged to a record $86bn in March, up by 48% year on year—the fastest growth in four decades. The increase is partly the result of semiconductor exports. Memory chips made by Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix, two big South Korean firms, are in high demand thanks to the AI frenzy.

The **Italian** men's football team failed to reach the World Cup for the third time in a row after losing a penalty shoot-out to Bosnia and Herzegovina. The four-time champions have not appeared at the tournament since 2014, or advanced to the knock-out stage since they won in 2006. Curacao, Cape Verde and Uzbekistan are among the countries making their debuts at this summer's tournament in America, Mexico and Canada.

Figure of the day: 15%, the drop in the price of gold since the start of the Iran war. Is the safe-haven asset becoming the new crypto?

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran’s exiled opposition loses momentum

Iran has organised hundreds of pro-regime demonstrations over the past month as a show of strength amid American and Israeli bombardment. It will no doubt do the same on Wednesday, when the country celebrates a holiday commemorating the referendum in 1979 that founded the Islamic Republic.

Iran’s exiled opposition—many of whom left around 1979, when the shah was overthrown—appeared to have momentum in the early days of the war. Crowds gathered in Western cities, some openly cheering strikes they believed would hasten the regime’s collapse. Reza Pahlavi, the shah’s son, cast the bombardment as a path to liberation.

That momentum is fading. As civilian casualties mount, rallies are thinning. The regime, meanwhile, is digging in, and using the war to justify repression. Mass protests inside Iran that were promised by Mr Pahlavi and his foreign backers have not materialised. When the fighting ends, unrest may return. But for now, Iran’s opposition remains too divided to offer a clear alternative.

Photograph: Getty Images

Japan’s “singles tax” debate

On Wednesday Japan introduces its “Child and Child-Rearing Contribution” system, financed by an addition to workers’ health-insurance premiums. Whether they have children or not, every worker will pay about ¥250 ($1.60) a month to support families that do. The intention is to tackle a deepening demographic crisis. In 2024 births dropped below 700,000 for the first time, the ninth straight annual decline.

The scheme is unpopular—critics are calling it a “singles tax”. With inflation rising, the yen weak and concerns over living costs growing, many resent the idea of subsidising others’ families.

The backlash reflects a broader social shift. By 2020 single-person households accounted for nearly 40% of the Japanese total, up from about 20% in the 1980s. Over the same period, the proportion with children fell from roughly 42% to 25%. A policy meant to coax singles into forming families has instead provoked their fury.

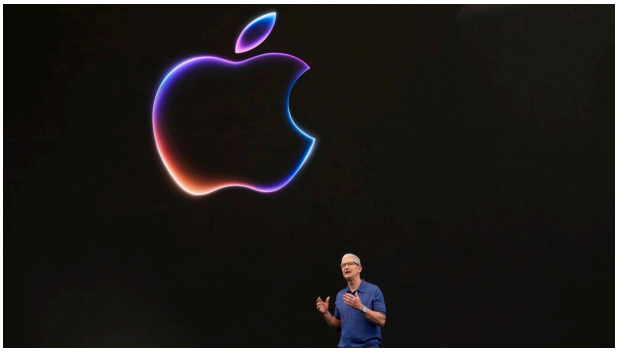
Photograph: Alamy

Birthright citizenship at SCOTUS

On Wednesday America's Supreme Court will grapple with one of President Donald Trump's most controversial executive orders: that babies born in America to undocumented immigrants or foreign visitors should no longer be entitled to citizenship.

The order, made on the first day of Mr Trump's second term, was immediately challenged as a violation of the 14th Amendment's guarantee of citizenship to "all persons born or naturalised in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof". Several courts blocked it—including a judge appointed by Ronald Reagan, who called the order "blatantly unconstitutional".

Mr Trump argues that undocumented immigrants and temporary visa holders are not "completely subject" to America's "political jurisdiction" because they lack a legal domicile. Challengers counter that this interpretation departs from the constitution's text and historical understanding. Despite Mr Trump's strong record at the court, most observers expect him to lose *Trump v Barbara*—an assessment shared by *The Economist*'s SCOTUSbot, an AI tool that predicts court rulings.



Photograph: AP

Apple’s mid-life crisis

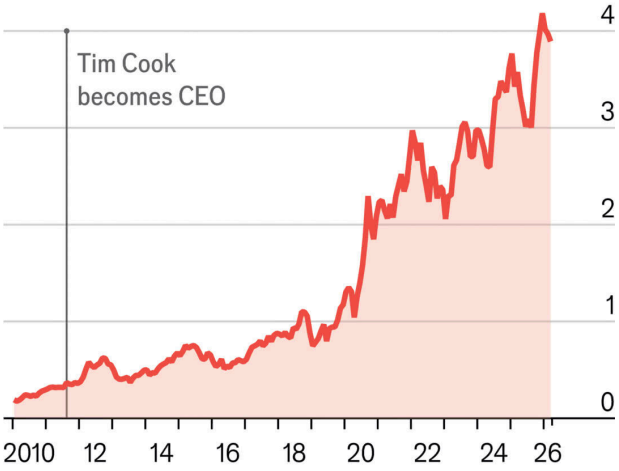
Apple celebrates its 50th birthday on Wednesday with a bash in California hosted by its boss, Tim Cook. Under his tenure, and that of his predecessor, Steve Jobs, the iPhone-maker has grown from a cultish brand into a colossus with a market value of $3.9trn.

But its fifties would be a good time for reinvention. The company wants to recapture its mojo: it is expected to introduce its first foldable phone this year and has recently released a cheap, colourful Mac laptop to widespread acclaim. New leadership could shake things up. John Ternus, head of hardware engineering, is reportedly being lined up to succeed Mr Cook.

The company is a laggard in AI: it has outsourced most of its efforts to Google’s Gemini chatbot. Siri, its voice assistant, needs to become much smarter. One day soon an AI-infused device might pose an existential threat to the iPhone. Hardware has always been Apple’s core; software remains its biggest challenge.

Juiced

Apple, market capitalisation, $trn



Source: LSEG Workspace

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

Tuesday: Who served as both American ambassador to the United Nations and director of the CIA in the 1970s?

When you want to fool the world, tell the truth.

Otto von Bismarck